

openhouse

raising curious humans, together.

student chess journal

level 1 · beginner · pawn → knight → bishop



my name _____

my coach _____

started _____

class _____

"every chess master was once a beginner."

to move up to intermediate, you reach the north star for every skill.

the 5 core skills & learning objectives

1 game mechanics

Understands basic rules – board setup, piece movement, coordinates, piece values; understands check, capture, checkmate (the primary objective) and stalemate; executes castling and pawn promotion correctly; identifies and flags illegal moves during play.

north star Implements the rules of the game and game-completion criteria; identifies and flags moves that break them as illegal – developing integrity, attention to detail, conflict resolution and accountability.

2 board vision

Maps the complete range of every piece to spot hanging targets instantly; communicates ideas clearly about a static position under discussion; reconstructs positions presented visually, verbally or in writing; tracks how every move shifts spatial balance – some squares controlled, some left behind.

north star Transforms the chessboard into a map, recognising the immediate threats of each piece – unlocking awareness, observation, spatial control and visualisation.

3 calculation

Tracks material balance during exchanges to ensure profitable trades; applies the CPR framework (Capture, Protect/Block, Run away) to escape check; holds legal-movement rules active in mind during play; evaluates the position constantly to judge who has the upper hand.

north star Applies working memory of piece rules, piece values and single-step conditional logic – fostering foundational decision-making, problem-solving, critical thinking and pattern recognition.

4 synthesis

Follows core opening rules (controls the central squares, develops minor pieces, castles early); avoids early-game pitfalls like Scholar's Mate, developing the queen early and unnecessary pawn moves; coordinates pieces by assigning specific roles in a strategy; recalls checkmate patterns during final execution.

north star Follows basic sequential rules and techniques to ensure clean development, planning and execution.

5 resilience

Displays courtesy by taking turns and respecting peers; manages immediate emotional reactions after a mistake or blunder; demonstrates complete focus during instruction and gameplay alike; accepts outcomes calmly – “All the best!” before and “Good game!” after.

north star Practises emotional self-regulation and respectful etiquette to ensure focused decision-making, patience and good sportsmanship.

progression milestones

milestone 1 · pawn 3 months

Establish foundational board awareness, master basic piece movements, and understand the primary goal of checkmate. Build early habits of analysing square safety and exercising patience during active play.

milestone 2 · knight 4 months

Transition from fundamental movements to active play – core opening principles, threat responses and elementary checkmate techniques. Develop competitive habits, learn the basics of algebraic notation, and practise focused gameplay.

milestone 3 · bishop 5 months

Transition from casual into competitive gameplay by executing foundational tactics, formulating basic strategies and mastering heavy-piece endgame mates. Solidify competitive habits through notation, tactical efficiency and active tournament & online play, preparing for intermediate competition.

each rank is earned by meeting all the criteria in the milestone passport (section 5).

1 tempo 10 min

2 min universal mind & movement + 5 min chess-centric warm-up drills (allowing for instruction & transition).

- 1.1 **pre-game centring & warm-up.** a 2-minute hands-free focus drill, then level-specific coordinate, board-vision or rapid tactical exercises – to ground focus, stop impulsive piece-grabbing and prime the brain.
- 1.2 **anecdotal sharing ("story time").** students share recent practice, home games, online puzzles or memorable chess moments – building rapport and validating effort.

2 chessiverse 35 min

an immersive tactical universe where theory becomes raw board mastery through puzzle sprints, custom mini-games and positional workouts.

- 2.1 **interactive concept lesson.** a demonstration of core milestone concepts using structured resources to encourage active reasoning.
- 2.2 **tactical board workouts.** setting up and solving tactical puzzles on physical boards from visual, verbal or written notation cues.
- 2.3 **directed positional workouts.** structured drills on physical boards to build tactile muscle memory.

3 rising pawns arena 35 min

the competitive main stage – full gameplay and teacher-led game analysis.

- 3.1 **paired gameplay & competition.** complete peer games with optional clocks, reinforcing tournament rules, illegal-move monitoring and sportsmanship.
- 3.2 **game analysis & recognition.** reviewing games from class, online or tournaments to celebrate strong moves and address learning moments – plus a monthly "game review day".

4 reflect & log 10 min

the class gathers at the demo board to review learnings, log journal updates and tally points on class teams days.

- 4.1 **closing reflection circle.** each player shares one personal takeaway and resets their board.



moving up a rank. promotion to the next rank means meeting all the criteria in section 5 (milestone passport) of this journal.

month 1

monthly focus

task 1 _____

task 2 _____

week	task 1	task 2	notes
wk 1	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 2	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 3	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 4	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	

month 2

monthly focus

task 1 _____

task 2 _____

week	task 1	task 2	notes
wk 1	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 2	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 3	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 4	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	

month 3

monthly focus

task 1 _____

task 2 _____

week	task 1	task 2	notes
wk 1	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 2	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 3	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	
wk 4	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	

month 4

monthly focus

task 1 _____

task 2 _____

week	task 1	task 2	notes
wk 1	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 2	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 3	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 4	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____

month 5

monthly focus

task 1 _____

task 2 _____

week	task 1	task 2	notes
wk 1	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 2	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 3	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 4	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____

month 6

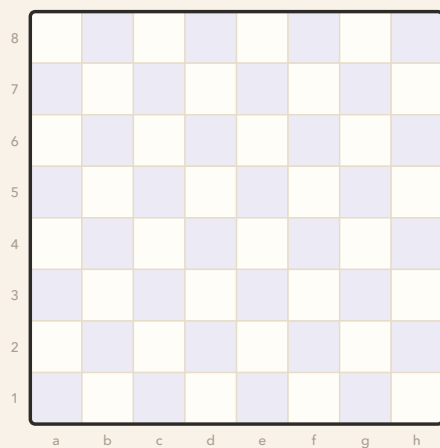
monthly focus

task 1 _____

task 2 _____

week	task 1	task 2	notes
wk 1	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 2	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 3	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____
wk 4	○ ○ ○ ○	○ ○ ○ ○	_____







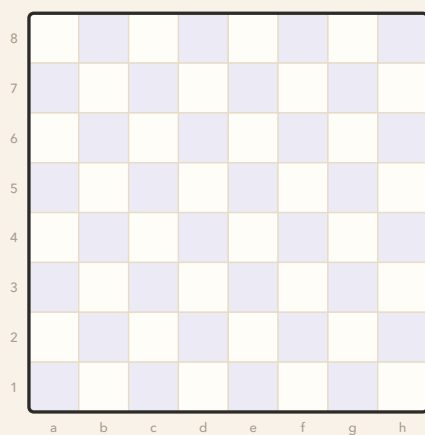
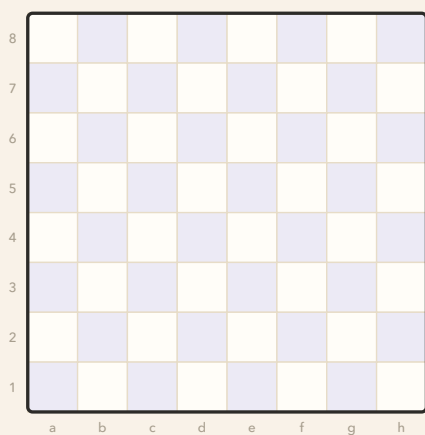
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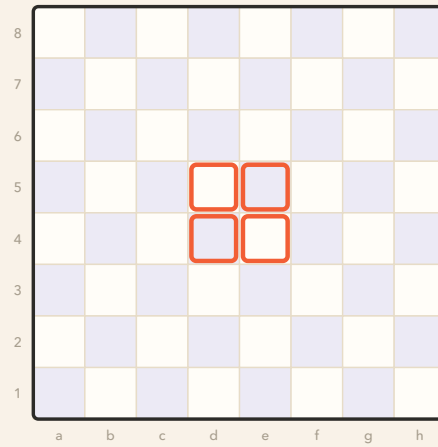
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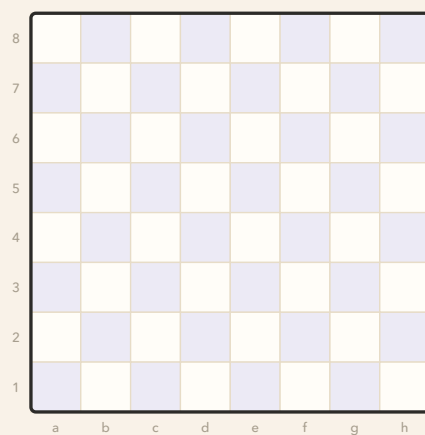
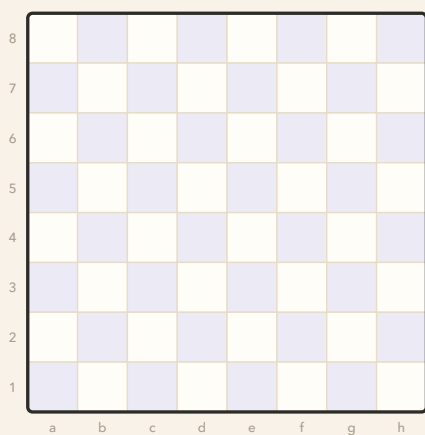
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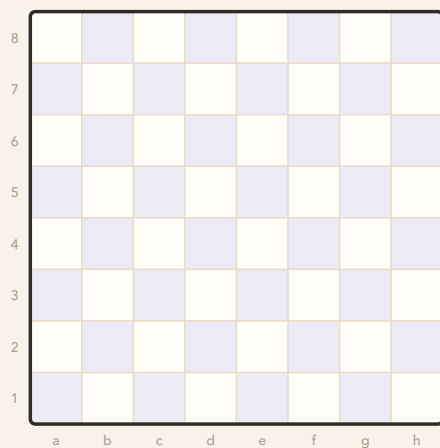














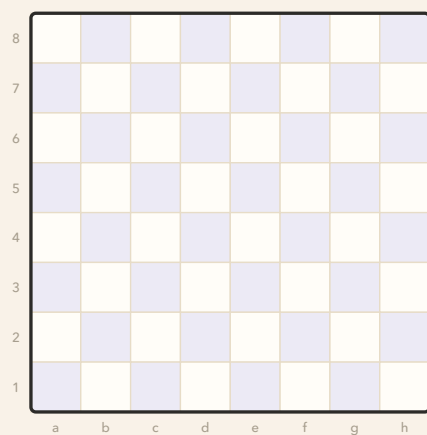
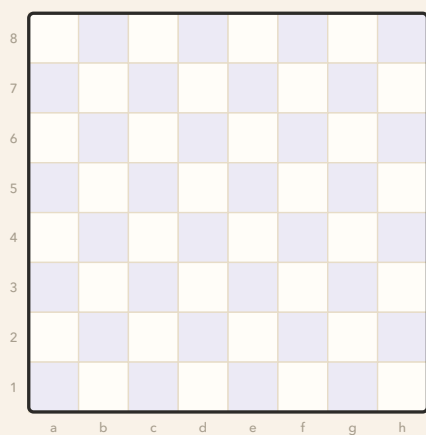
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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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month games w l d

my biggest improvement

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the mistake i make most

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tick the pattern to work on

- ☐ **opening:** repeated piece moves · neglecting the centre or king safety
- ☐ **tactics:** rushed calculation · missing hanging pieces & opponent threats
- ☐ **position:** leaving pieces undefended · inactive piece placement
- ☐ **resilience:** moving impulsively · emotional drop after a blunder

my number-one focus for next month

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

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my number-one focus for next month

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student coach

date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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one thing i learned today

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date opponent result ☐w ☐l ☐d

one thing i learned today

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month games w l d

my biggest improvement

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the mistake i make most

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tick the pattern to work on

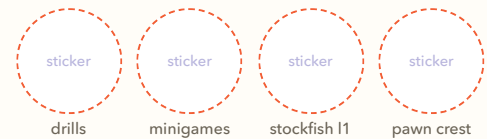
- ☐ **opening:** repeated piece moves · neglecting the centre or king safety
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my number-one focus for next month

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milestone 1 · pawn

- ☐ Challenges Stockfish Level 1 in a full game that ends in checkmate or stalemate. (milestone challenge 1)
- ☐ Completes starting-position setup, puzzle-position setup and piece-movement drills with 100% accuracy. (continuous)
- ☐ Plays the mini-games – chain capture, board architect (visual), bees & lilies and last man standing – with confidence. (continuous)
- ☐ Solves mate-in-one and hanging-piece puzzles, clearly telling check from checkmate and hanging from protected pieces. (continuous)



coach signature _____

date _____

milestone 2 · knight

- ☐ Beats Stockfish Level 2 in a full game while adhering to competitive rules of play. (milestone challenge 1)
- ☐ Participates in the mandatory showcase event and optional online tournaments for match experience. (continuous)
- ☐ Demonstrates core opening principles while correctly applying castling and pawn-promotion rules. (continuous)
- ☐ Confidently solves time-bound mate-in-1 and hanging-piece challenges with high accuracy. (milestone challenge 2)
- ☐ Executes a clean queen & rook roller checkmate, finishing efficiently without stalemate. (milestone challenges 3 & 4)
- ☐ Reads & writes basic algebraic notation to record moves (e.g. first 10 moves of a game). (continuous)

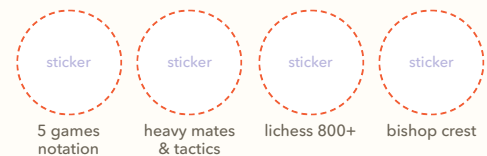


coach signature _____

date _____

milestone 3 · bishop

- ☐ Plays 5 full competitive games in complete algebraic notation, consciously practising the touch-move rule. (milestone challenge 1)
- ☐ Identifies illegal moves accurately and reports each as it occurs, ending the game if either player commits 3. (continuous)
- ☐ Executes clean two-rook roller and solo-queen checkmates efficiently without stalemate. (milestone challenges 2 & 3)
- ☐ Understands minimum checkmating material and two draws – stalemate and insufficient material (two kings). (continuous)
- ☐ Solves time-bound medium mate-in-1 puzzles and basic tactical patterns. (milestone challenges 4 & 5)
- ☐ Participates in a mandatory intra/inter-Openhouse showcase plus regular online practice. (continuous)
- ☐ Crosses a Lichess Rapid rating of 800 once (dropping below later does not break this). (milestone challenge 6)



coach signature _____

date _____

collectible masters – for consistency, resilience & tactics



anand



carlsen



gukesh



praggnanandhaa



divya

datetablewhiteblacktime

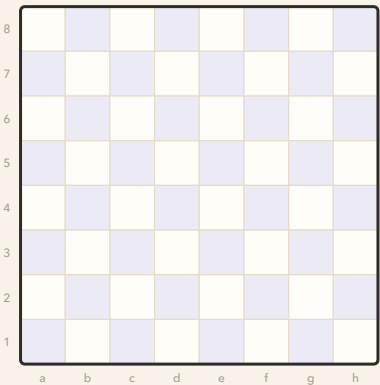
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2			32		
3			33		
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28			58		
29			59		
30			60		

☐ 1-0☐ 0-1☐ ½-½

illegal moves flagged
white☐☐☐ black☐☐☐

white
black
coach

final / critical position



"Every chess master was once a beginner."

– irving chernev

"When you see a good move, look for a better one."

– emanuel lasker

"Tactics is knowing what to do when there is something to do; strategy is knowing what to do when there is nothing to do."

– savielly tartakower

"Nobody ever won a chess game by resigning."

– savielly tartakower

"In chess, as in life, a person is their own most dangerous opponent."

– vasily smyslov

"The hardest game to win is a won game."

– emanuel lasker